

CHAPTER TEN

Making a Career Change

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This was the year that I made a major career change, so I am interrupting the narrative to devote space to my five years (1968 - 1973) in the Personnel Management Staff, which eventually become known as the Personnel Evaluation and Counseling Staff of which I was the Chief. My role as an operational officer wasn't going too well. I was a senior officer (GS-15) and just couldn't go along with what seemed to me a paranoia of some of my superiors. Also the division was changing constantly and some people became my superiors for whom I had little respect either personally or professionally. Consequently, I used my connections to get appointed to what was known then as the Personnel Management Staff, headed by Gerald Miller, an old-time O.S.S. officer and a person with a lot of clout in the Clandestine Services.

My experience of over 18 active years in operations proved to be a fundamental part of the success which I eventually achieved in my new assignment. At the time that I joined the PMS, it was a small staff consisting of six senior officers all with extensive operational experience. The head of the staff, who was on the verge of retiring, wanted to change a number of the personnel practices which had been left far too long in the hands of the "personnel technicians" most of whom had never had a managerial assignment, had never faced any of the problems with which the operations officers were constantly confronted, and consequently really didn't have the foggiest notion as to how to properly counsel them with respect to their careers.

The idea of this staff was to concentrate on the junior officers or career trainees as they were called and establish a regular counselor-trainee relationship with them. To accomplish this, we each took a proportionate share of the new trainees averaging about two comprehensive interviews and counseling sessions per day. Following each interview, a memo for the file was made of all the essential points covered-such memo to be retained only in the files of the PMS since we did not want, under any circumstances, for this material to work its way into any official personnel files. This took a really high level decision, surprisingly enough, since the Personnel people could not conceive of such "valuable" information not being available for future reference. Our commitment to the trainees, however, was quite straight-forward. They were to regard all consultations as absolutely risk free so that they could sound off on anything or any person which was bugging them. So we stuck to our guns and never permitted the material to get out of our hands, although there were occasions when certain action was called for or necessary in behalf of the CT and such was taken only after his permission to move on such was given. In this way we were able to establish a high

degree of rapport with these young officers. They appreciated the opportunity to discuss their careers with seasoned veterans rather than just personnel officers. I was the deputy chief of the staff and due to the impending retirement of the chief much of the planning as to the tone of the staff fell on my shoulders.

Like so many things that start out with one basic concept in mind, i.e. dealing with the new officers (there was a feeling amongst some people that everyone else was a lost cause so far as his career was concerned- he had either made it or not), the responsibilities of this staff grew like topsy. Contrary to the misconception stated above, there were a lot of officers, particularly at the middle grades (GS 12-13) who were still very much interested in their careers. The staff, consequently, began to be involved in all sorts of problem-solving and trouble-shooting cases involving the careers of quite a substantial number of officers.

Prior to Mr. Miller's retirement, and to utilize his considerable clout, I suggested that the entire personnel evaluation program needed restructuring at minimum and thrown out and started over at maximum. I got the go ahead from Miller and proceeded to knock down the traditions that had been built up over about twenty years and recommended some rather drastic changes. Prior to making such recommendations, I studied the career evaluation programs of the Foreign Service, the Navy, Army and Department of Defense civilian personnel. Since our CIA operatives equated more closely with the Foreign Service (many of our people used Foreign Service as a cover - I did myself for thirteen years), I spent many hours with the Chiefs of the Foreign Service Selection Boards and Career Counseling, literally walking through step by step all of their procedures, querying as to the strengths and weaknesses of each process, and striving to arrive at an ideal arrangement which would incorporate their experience yet be applicable to CIA's unique problems and the different types of careers which existed in our organization.

Having done my homework, I was ready to launch my program. By this time the concern of the regular personnel staff was very high, because these people realized that what I was proposing (viz. that the operations people take over the evaluation and promotion of their own officers) would, in effect, reduce the traditional power which the Personnel Office had held for so long. However, I was well-prepared for this eventuality. My studies had revealed that in the course of a fifteen year period only 108 persons had served on the so-called competitive boards. Some had sat on as many as eleven boards at the same grade level. It was quite apparent that objectivity was a very difficult thing under such conditions and that the old buddy, old school tie or

whatever system you want to call it was running the show. After looking at it as carefully as I did, I often wondered how I had managed to get promoted to a senior grade officer since I really didn't belong to any of these elite cliques. In fact, I found that I had many friends in high places, who had pushed my promotions mainly because of my competence - a rather rare thing to say the least.

It wasn't until Jerry Miller's retirement, however, that I was able to get the new evaluation concept underway. The Deputy Director for Plans (the Clandestine Services), Tom Karamessines, was receptive to at least a trial running of a board under the concept which I had proposed, namely that we at least try it under the precepts (which I myself drafted) at the GS-12 level and then after evaluating the results initiate at another level at six month intervals. Because of the tradition-bound division chiefs and personnel staffs who served them, the prospect of some of their power being diluted almost scuttled the program at several points.

However, I had made such a convincing argument to the Deputy Director that he backed me up all the way. We started the board which was convened full time to evaluate all officers at the GS-12 level (some 500 of them) and the board consisted in the main of officers at the 15 and 16 level. My contention was that any operations officer could be objectively evaluated by competent operations officers at least two grades higher. For the initial program I had to compromise at 3 and 4 levels higher. Without belaboring the point more, this board, which was convened full-time for a minimum of six weeks, was so ecstatic about the process that reports of such quickly reached the DDP who summoned me to his office, said that it looked as if I had made my point and asked me to prepare to evaluate the GS-13's starting two weeks after completion of the GS-12 program.

I was quite unprepared for this degree of immediate success but wasn't about to let the opportunity slip away. While I would have preferred to work out the kinks in an orderly way after completion and review of the results of the first board, I now found that I not only had to do such an analysis but make the preparations for a continuing series of boards. The first GS-12 board had started in March 1969 and that year we completed boards for 13, 14, 15 and 16 and initiated one in the fall at the GS-11 level. Needless to say, I didn't get much rest, or leave, or anything but a lot of work. But I had won - which was the name of the game and the rewards were immediately forthcoming - not so much that I myself got promoted to a grade GS-16 (equivalent to a General Officer in the military) but that I had won the respect and gratitude of thousands of operations officers who had been awaiting a more objective system for their entire career (including a lot of very competent but overlooked female officers.)

The vast majority of people who got promoted or did not get promoted never really knew why or how the process worked under the previous system. Under the system which I established, all the criteria was spelled out in advance, everyone knew the basis upon which promotions were to be granted, they understood the process (not initially, of course) by which every officer was looked at in depth by a group of officers at least two grades senior and who could not repeat on the same board until at least two years had elapsed. This was to avoid any recollection of the ranking given to any officer in a previous year, whether it was close to the top or near the bottom.

A natural corollary to the evaluation process was the broadening of our counseling responsibilities. I had the name of the staff changed to reflect more accurately its functions, viz. Personnel Evaluation and Counseling. The former provided a much more equitable and objective method of evaluation and the latter function (counseling), a third party procedure by which each officer evaluated by the board could review those factors which influenced the board's decision. The years of 1971 and 1972 were spent in fine-tuning the evaluation process and in extending the work of the Boards to cover all grades from GS-8 through GS-16. It was my responsibility to insure that all precepts or criteria for each board were reviewed and up-dated according to the specific needs of the directorate. By this time it was necessary to enlarge the staff to attempt to cope with the many functions which we had assumed. The Boards met almost continuously, except for several months during the summer when vacations were in order, not only for the staff, but for those who served on the evaluation boards.

I utilized this period of time for dealing with other matters which required attention. For one thing, to establish an equitable appeal system for persons who had fallen in the low 5% of his grade level one year and was found in the low 3% the next. Such a ranking required that some sort of administrative action be taken. There were some people, naturally, who wanted such action to be an automatic selection out (similar to what existed in the Foreign Service) I felt that because of the peculiarities of the intelligence trade that selection out should certainly not be automatic and that every effort should be made to assure that the findings of the evaluation boards got a comprehensive review under such circumstances. Consequently, a review system was established and monitored, as well as administered by our staff. It proved to be quite successful and certainly allayed the fears of collusion and railroading.

The counseling of all officers between the grades of GS-8 and 16 continued on a regular basis during the entire

year. While I was able to keep myself fairly well involved in this activity, particularly with regard to the higher graded officers, I delegated the major part of individual counseling cases to my staff, all of which continued to be composed of experienced operations officers, including female officers, although every effort was made to keep the situation from becoming polarized. In most cases, the credentials of the female officers were of high enough quality that male officers did not have any concern about being counseled by one.

Due to the success of our evaluation process in the Plans Directorate, other directorates of the Agency were interested in applying the concepts to their situations. I was, therefore, constantly in demand for providing briefings to high-level officials of other directorates. A senior officer was usually appointed for a one year period to serve as the overall chairman of the evaluation boards, operating under my tutelage and guidance. One such officer, a GS-18, wrote a very complimentary memorandum following one of my briefings. I don't remember the exact wording of it but he said in effect that he had been extremely proud to have been a part of the presentation and that, in his opinion, Mr. Harris represented the directorate as one of its finest officers. I didn't know that such a memorandum existed until months afterwards when it was shown to me by the Deputy Director of Plans. I was also called upon regularly to present the concepts of the evaluation boards and career counseling to a Senior Officer Seminar which was convened semi-annually and which consisted of officers GS-16 and above from all the Agency's Directorates.

At the time, in early 1973, that James Schlesinger became Director of CIA, there was a general reduction in force in the Agency. By nature, I prefer to do things rationally, orderly, systematically and fairly. At this time, however, the entire Agency became almost panic-stricken because of the tactics used by Schlesinger in his so-called weeding out process. Fortunately, because of the evaluation system which had been in force for several years as a result of my initiative, our directorate had ample data to utilize for the reduction in force effort. The records which our staff maintained on the rank-order status of each officer served as a useful tool for making some very difficult decisions. For a period of five to six weeks in the Spring of 1973 I worked almost daily with Bill Colby, then DD of Operations, to try to make what we hoped to be an equitable selection of personnel who, under the difficult circumstances of the time, could no longer serve usefully in the service.

Because of my reputation as a fair and straight forward counselor many of the people who had been selected to leave the Agency came to me for advice as to how they

could make the transition from the world of espionage to the outside world. My general thrust was to have them inventory their various skills and talents -not as intelligence officers, per se but in their dealing with humans beings. Most were highly educated, academically, but there is no such thing as a formal type of education for intelligence work. We had people with all kinds of backgrounds, both scientific and liberal arts, fluent in foreign languages, people with law degrees as well as PhD's in such things as music and art. Some day when all the books have been published "exposing" the CIA, a creative person will write something about the types of individuals who dedicated long careers out in the cold of the intelligence world.

It was at the end of this difficult period of time, that I informed Mr. Colby, already designated as the new Director of Central Intelligence, replacing Schlesinger who had moved over to Defense, that I had to seek a disability retirement because of a constantly increasing sacro-lumbar deterioration. He was much chagrined because he said that he had some important things which he wanted me to do for him at the upper levels of the Agency. Mr. Colby awarded me upon my retirement the Intelligence Medal of Merit, the Agency's second highest medal, interestingly enough not just because of my contributions in the intelligence field but because of the major contribution that I had made in personnel management.